



◀ HIGH FLUSH

This 1912 toilet has a raised cistern—gravity helped to increase the speed and power of the flush.

Water flushed from the cistern down the pipe into the toilet.

PORCELAIN TOILET

A major breakthrough in toilet technology was the one-piece ceramic toilet, designed by the British pottery manufacturer Thomas Twyford in the 1880s. Where previous models had been enclosed within wooden boxes, this new model, like the ornate example on the left, was free-standing, making it easier to clean.



The hinged wooden seat could be raised or lowered over the toilet.

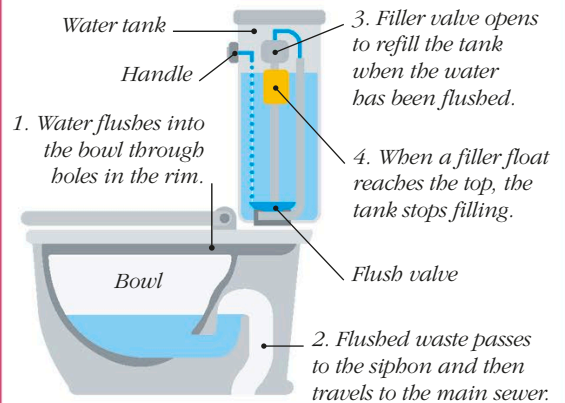
The seat temperature can be controlled by the user.

SUPER TOILETS

Since the 1970s, Japan has specialized in creating technologically advanced toilets. These usually have additional features, such as seat warmers, automatic lids, deodorizers, and even speakers for playing music—all managed by a control panel. The high-tech toilets are sometimes known as “washlets,” after one of the most popular Japanese brands.

HOW A TOILET WORKS

When you push the handle, it opens the flush valve, letting water from the tank flow into the bowl. Water and waste are then sucked out of the bowl down the siphon and away to the sewer. A U-bend traps water in the bottom of the bowl, stopping smells from the sewer escaping back into the toilet.



TOILET PAPER

The Chinese were probably the first people to use toilet paper in around the 6th century. In the West, its invention is credited to the American inventor Joseph Gayetty, in 1857, although toilet paper on a roll was invented in 1890 by brothers Clarence and E. Irvin Scott. It was not a success until the 20th century because people were embarrassed to buy it.

